

new tunes

MUSIC IS GOVERNED BY THE HEART AND NOT BY GENDER. THESE WOMEN INSTRUMENTALISTS PROVE IT BY MAKING WAVES IN A MALE BASTION.

Sharan Rani Backliwal, 78, still recalls that hot summer day when she packed up her bags with just two cotton saris and left Delhi for Maihar in Madhya Pradesh. The 19-year-old had fought with her affluent parents, travelled by train, changed two buses and walked miles to reach that obscure, sleepy little town. But for her, the travails of the journey hardly mattered. It was a wonder quest to find herself. It was the promised land, where her dreams of learning to play the sarod could come true.

Long considered a male prerogative, the sarod had few takers among women. But Sharan Rani was determined to change all that and take lessons from the legendary musician, Baba Allaudin Khan. She was only the second woman to have learnt from Baba, the first being his own daughter, Annapurna Devi herself.

That was then. Today, like Sharan Rani, a host of women instrumentalists has not just stormed the male bastion but become role models in their own right: violin maestro Pandit Omkar Nath Thakur felt proud to have N. Rajam as his disciple; tabla

maestros Ustad Allah Rakha and Ustad Zakir Hussain mention Anuradha Pal in their list of star students; and the legendary vocalist, Pandit Jasraj can't stop praising his violinist pupil, Kala Ramnath.

The journey to the pinnacle of success, however, has not been easy. As Sharan Rani recalls, she had to leave behind her family for a considerable period of time, not to mention the luxury of cars and an über-urban lifestyle during her apprenticeship as Baba's student. Her guru was an advocate of a spartan lifestyle: his house lacked running water or toilets.

kamala shankar

SHANKAR GUITAR

Few women dare to do what Kamala Shankar did. The only woman guitar player in Hindustani classical music, she has modified the instrument to suit her style of music. "I created a modified version of the Hawaiian guitar and named it after the deity, Shankar bhagwan, who presides over Varanasi." Born in Tanjore, Tamil Nadu, Shankar's musical career started at the age of six, with vocal music lessons from her mother. She clubbed that with lessons from vocalist Pandit Chhanulal Mishra of Benaras gharana and learnt sitar from Pandit Bimalendu Mukherjee of Imdadkhani gharana. A soloist in her own right, she has won many awards. The accuracy of the *meends* and the *chikari* variations in the *jhala* sections leave the audience spellbound. "There was music in the family, so it was easy for me to take it up professionally, but it's demanding and one can't afford to take it easy," she says. Besides graduating in science, she has a doctorate in music from Benaras University. Shankar and her husband, Rajeev Janardhan (sitar player) together formed the Shankara Orchestra.

saskia rao-de-haas

CELLO

Born in Holland, Rao took to the cello at the age of eight. The turning point in her career came years later when she was doing a course in Ethnomusicology at Amsterdam University. At a North Indian classical music session she realised her propensity for Indian classical music and enrolled at the Conservatory of Rotterdam, where eminent Indians like Pandit Hari Prasad Chaurasia and Koustav Ray were visiting professors. During her visits to India, she studied under Sumati Mutatkar, Pandit D.K. Datar and Deepak Chowdhury.

What is amazing is Rao's efforts to learn the rudiments and modify the instrument. "I had to develop my own techniques through different teachers and constant research," she says.

Music director Vishal Bharadwaj was so impressed with her that he made her play in *Maqbool*. She has also collaborated with Bharat Natyam dancer Geeta Chandran. "Indian music allows freedom of improvisation," says Rao. Indian music apart, she has experimented with the Flamenco guitar and Western classical music.

